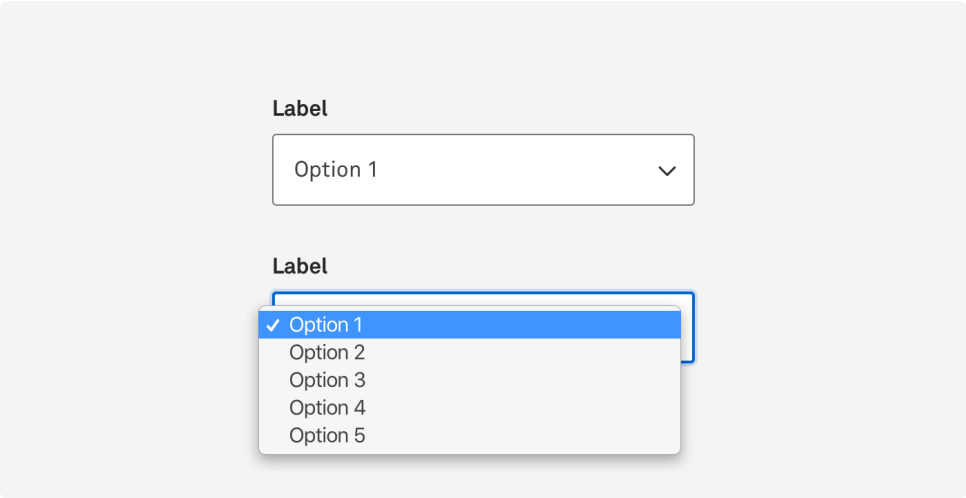
*Need help? Self-Service || Yammer || **No new spaces from Nov-23rd***

Select

Created by Hillary Purssey, last modified by Tony Wang on 08 Mar 2021



Select allows users to select a single option from a list that contains multiple options. It's designed to be used within a form only, and the selected value is submitted on form submission.

Version

1

Availability

Web

On This Page

- Usage Guidelines
- Pros & Cons of Using Selects
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- Best Practices
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Useful Docs

- Offering Smart Default Option

Specs

- Select (Web)

UI Playground

- Web Playground
- React Playground

Usage Guidelines

Use 'Select':

- Within a web form only.
- To display a list of different options that does not trigger actions immediately. See example in Best Practices.
- To allow users to select 1 option from a pre-defined list.

Recommendation (Soft Rule):

- To display 5–15 options in Select (as recommended by NNG).
- There may be scenarios where it's acceptable when the number of options is <5 or 15+. Please review with your UX Leads & Able Team for exceptions.
- If you have 3 or 4 options for user to choose from, consider Radio Group if its more appropriate.
- Keep in mind, Select with 15+ options makes it difficult for users to see all options and change selection easily.

Don't use 'Select':

- To perform actions (or commands) upon on selection. For example: Sort by.
- When you want user to perform multi selection, use Checkbox Group instead.

Pros & Cons of Using Selects

Select should be used to display a list with 5–15 options when there's a limited screen space available.

There are advantages and disadvantages of using the Select pattern:

Pros

- ✅ Pre-defined options reduce input errors
- ✅ Can be used with limited screen space
- ✅ Gives user optimal option by default
- ✅ Familiarity with browser UI

Cons

- ❌ Hides all options from user
- ❌ Slows users down (to complete their tasks)
- ❌ Difficult to scan when there are too many options
- ❌ Requires multiple steps to change selection (on Desktop & Mobile Web)

Patterns to use instead of Select

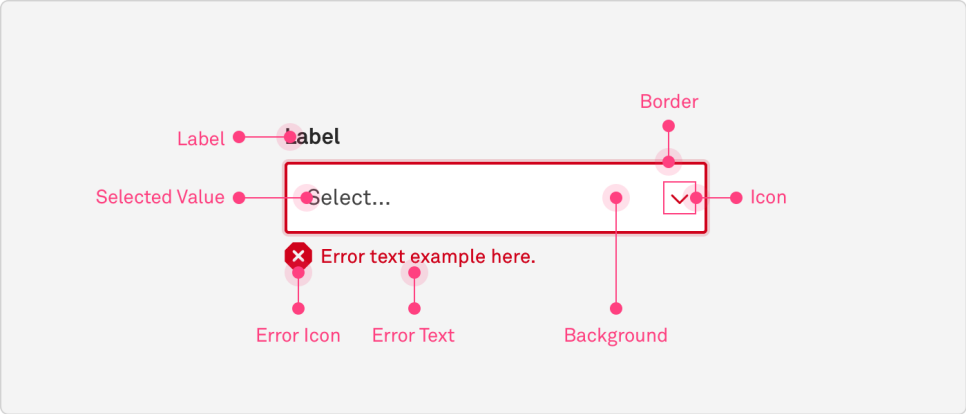
Previous studies, tech talks and articles have indicated that Select may not always be the most appropriate control to use, as it requires additional interaction cost from user and may impact user task success rate.

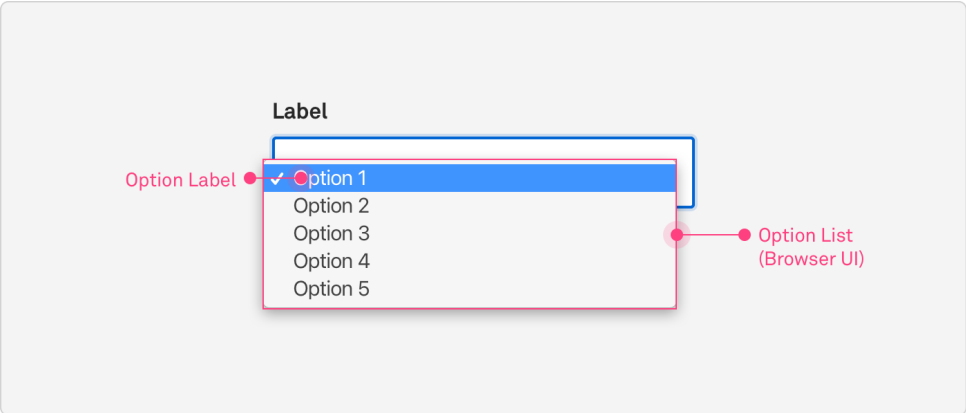
Follow the general guidelines on picking the appropriate input controls to use:

Data Type	Checkbox	Checkbox Group	Radio Group	Text Field
Yes/No question	✅		✅	
Single selection with 2–5 options			✅	
Multi selection		✅		
Undefined number of options (e.g age / amount)				✅

For more scenarios, see other recommendations.

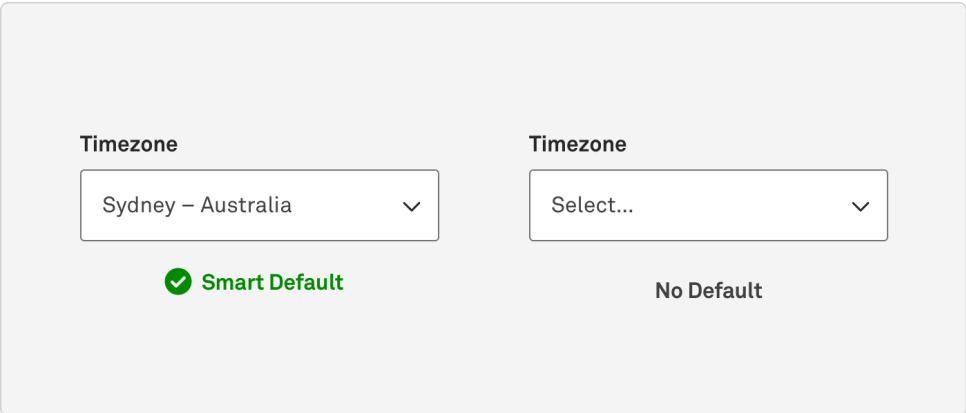
Anatomy





Select displays a list of options called *Option List* — UI presented by the browser.

Offer Smart Default



A *Smart Default* is an option that is selected by default, and is the most desired or frequently selected option based on user's context and needs.

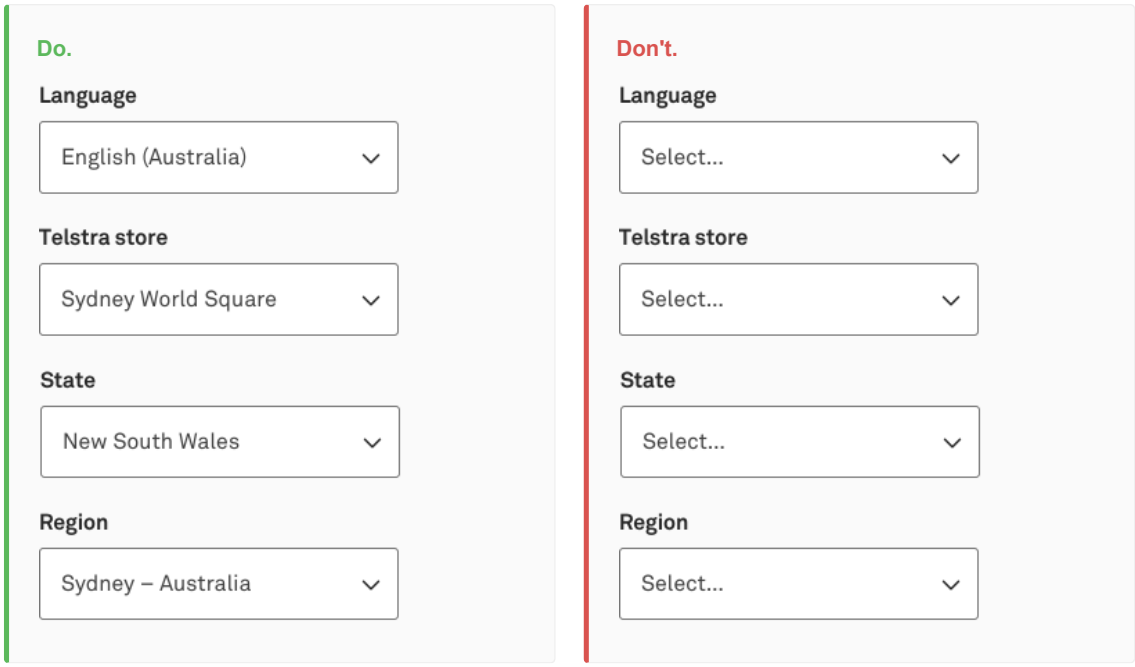
See Offering Smart Default Option for more detailed guidance.

For Select, you can use the following information to help you determine your default option:

- Current timestamp (for appointment booking)

- User's location (for finding store locations)
- User's OS settings (for languages or region)
- and more...

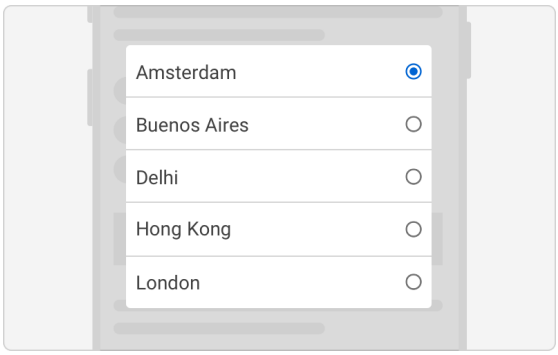
Example:



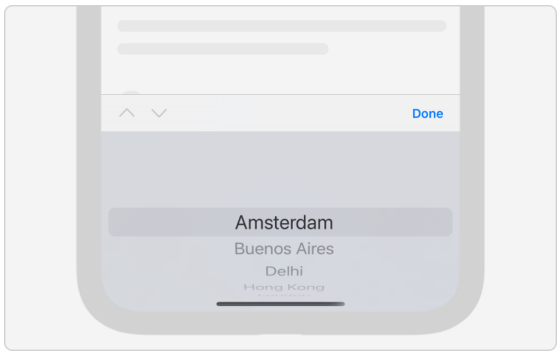
Select UI on Mobile Web

Select uses Browser UI to display the Option List, see below for the differences in Android and iOS.

Mobile Chrome (Android)



Mobile Safari (iOS)



States

There are 2 supported states in Select:

- Default state
- Error state — when a user has failed to make a required selection.

For each state, there are 4 different interaction states

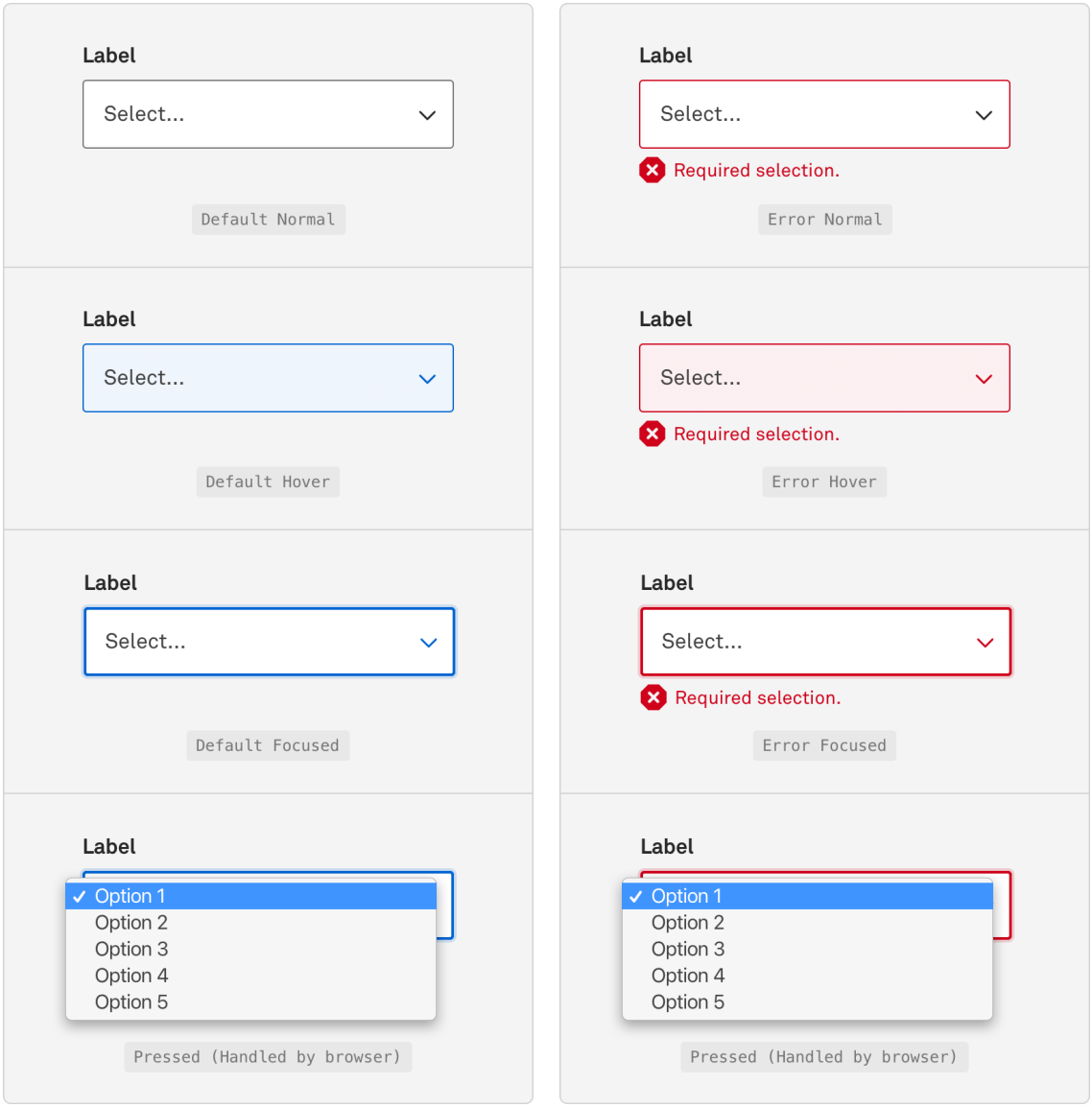
1. Normal
2. Hover
3. Focused
4. Pressed (Handled by browser, no custom visual treatment)

Keep in mind:

- '*Focused state*' is triggered by mouse click or keyboard navigation.
- '*Disabled state*' is not supported in Select. See why we don't support disabled state.
- The *'Error state'* should only be triggered if a Selection is required and a user has failed to make a selection.

Default States

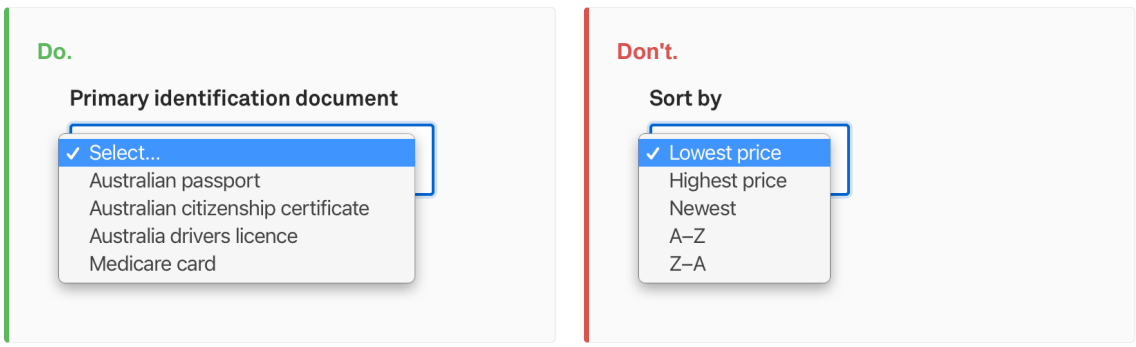
Error States



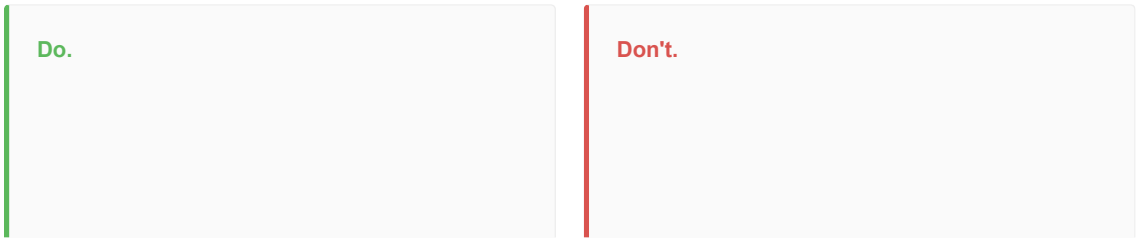
Find out more details on the different states, see Interaction States.

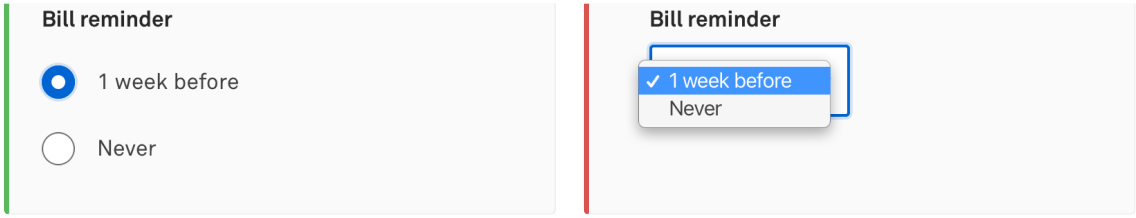
Best Practices

- **Provide list of options, not actions.**
  Select should provide a list of options users can change between, not a list of actions that users can perform immediately.

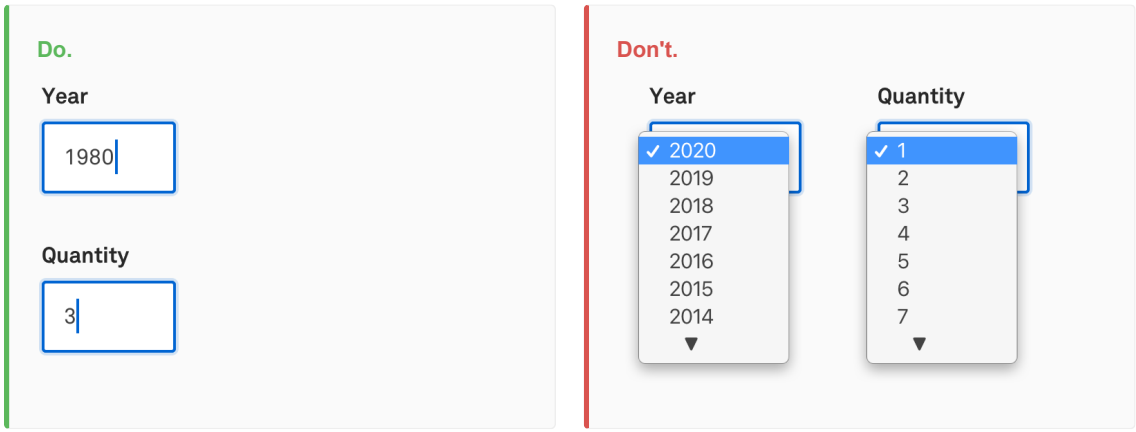


- **Don't use Select if you only have 2 options for users to choose from.**

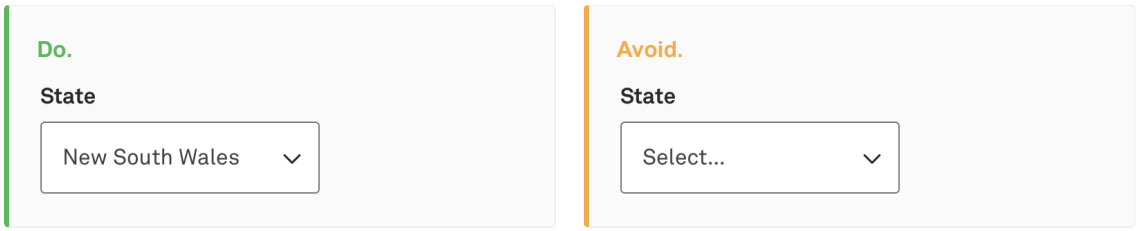




- **Don't use select for a long list of continuous numbers.**
  If you have a long list of numbers as the options. Text Field is typically more efficient for users than scrolling and selecting one from a long list of options.

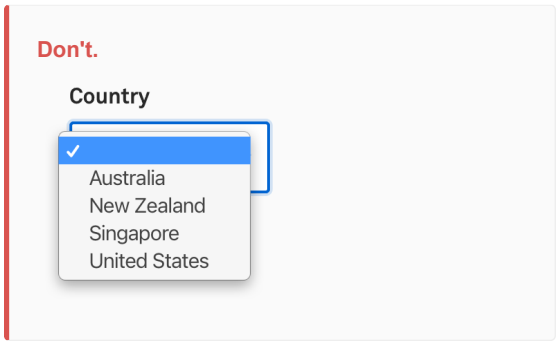


- **Provide smart default whenever possible.**
  To streamline user flow, it's recommend to preselect an appropriate option from the list. e.g. We can preselect state based on user's location. Learn more from Offering Smart Default Option.

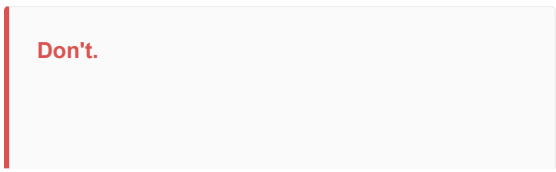


- **Always provide a label in Select.**
  Don't assume the purpose of a Select is self-explanatory by just looking at the options.

- **Option labels in the option list should never be empty.**



- **Avoid long option labels.**
  Keep option labels short and succinct according to the selected width. Long option labels can get truncated and makes it difficult for users to see the selected value.



Secret question

What is the name of the street you gr

- **Select is a required field by Default unless marked with optional.**
  Similar to Text Field guidelines, form fields are required by default unless it's marked with (optional) in the label. Keep in mind, avoid asking users to provide information that isn't really needed.

Do.

Favourite cuisine

Select...

Don't.

Favourite cuisine (required)

Select...

Content Guidelines

This section provides guidance on how to write effective copy for each text elements in this pattern (also documented in Telstra's Content Style Guide):

1. Label
2. Selected Value
3. Option label
4. Error text

1. Label

A select **always** contains a label which clearly describes what the list of options represent. Don't use it without a label.

When writing a label:

- Clearly describe the grouping category for context and clarity. Keep it succinct, no longer than a single sentence/question.
- Always use singular form, not plural, to indicate that user can select only 1 option.

Do.

Additional ID

Select...

Don't.

Additional IDs

Select...

- Keep it consistent with the other labels in Text Field and Checkbox Group within the same page.
- Use sentence case.

2. Selected Value

The Selected Value is the text displayed in the Select (box/field) that represents the selected option. You should offer users a smart default where possible.

If there's no appropriate default option, you can add a placeholder option "Select…" as your first option.

- The placeholder option should end with an ellipsis symbol (**…**), not 3 individual full stops.
- Keep it short, avoid being unnecessarily verbose.

Do.

Company

Select...

Don't.

Company

---Please choose one option---

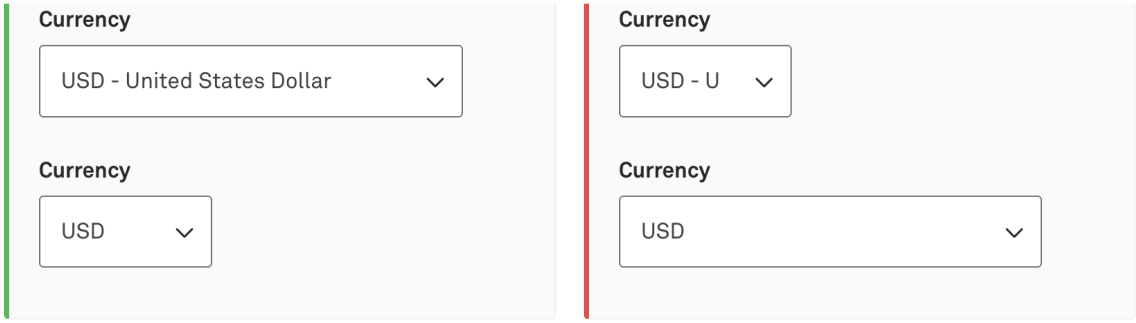
3. Option Label

Each option label should make sense as individual items and as part of an option list. They should:

- Be written concisely according to the select width. Ensure the full option label is visible in selected view, otherwise consider using a different viewport or adjusting the length of labels.

Do.

Don't.

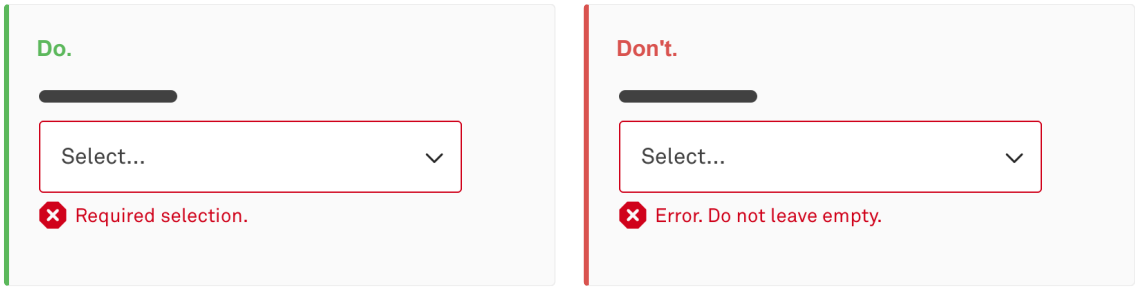


- Be listed in logical order that makes sense according to the selection options (e.g. alphabetical, ascending, etc.)
- Be written in sentence case.
- Avoid punctuation.

4. Error Text

In a Select, an error will be only be shown if they are a required field and user hasn't select a legitimate option (other than the "select…" option).

Error text should always be '**Required selection.**'.



Accessibility Considerations

Select is designed to meet the WCAG 2.1 Success Criteria outlined below. All requirements should be considered and understood when using the pattern. Requirements marked with ⚠️ indicate partial compliance which must be met in build or authoring.

- 1.1.1 Non-text Content (A) - Informative icons, such as those used in error messages, contain text alternatives ⚠️
- 1.3.1 Info and Relationships (A) - Select contain a label that is programmatically associated with the field
- 1.4.3 Contrast Minimum (AA) - All text meets the 4.5:1 contrast ratio
- 1.4.4 Resize Text (AA) - When resized to 200%, text is not truncated
- 1.4.11 Non Text Contrast (AA) - Aspects of the select required for identification meet the contrast ratio of 3:1
- 1.4.12 Text Spacing (AA) - Text spacing can be increased without loss of content
- 2.1.1 Keyboard (A) - Select are keyboard accessible
- 2.4.3 Focus Order (A) - Select follow a sequential focus order ⚠️
- 2.4.6 Headings and Labels (AA) Select have descriptive labels ⚠️
- 2.4.7 Focus Visible (AA) - Select has a clear visible focus state
- 2.5.3 Label in Name (A) - The accessible name of the select matches the visible label
- 2.5.5 Target Size (AAA) - The touch target size is at least 48 x 48 (dp/pt/px)
- 3.3.1 Error Identification (A) - Select errors are identified and described in text ⚠️
- 3.3.2 Labels or Instructions (A) - Labels and instructional text are clear and unambiguous ⚠️
- 3.3.3 Error Suggestion (AA) - Clear and unambiguous information is provided to help users correct input errors when they occur ⚠️
- 3.4.2 Consistent Identification (AA) - Select that capture the same data also contain the same label ⚠️
- 4.1.1 Parsing (A) - Select use valid HTML/markup/code
- 4.1.2 Name, Role, Value (A) - Select are marked up correctly to expose the correct name and role to assistive technology

Keyboard

Interaction	Keystrokes	Notes
Navigating / expand / collapse	↑ / ↓ - navigate between menu options SPACEBAR - expand the options list ESCAPE - if the options list is displayed, collapse the list and move focus back to the select *Depending on your browser there are some differences with keyboard interactions. These are centred around which keys should expand the options list, which keys should select the current option and close the dropdown, and whether pressing escape should revert selection to the previously selected option.*	You can also filter by typing letters, but this behaviour varies by browser. Some will filter as you type, like autocomplete. Others will only sort by first letter. E.g., in a list of US States, hitting A then R may take you to **A**rizona, or it may take you to **Alabama** and then **R**hode Island.

Screen Reader

Screen reader behaviour and the ordering of announcements will vary depending on the platform/browser/screen reader combinations being used.

On screen reader focus of select announcements must include:

- The **label** of the select
- The **role** ie "Combobox" or "Popup button"
- The **value** ie. the option label that's currently selected

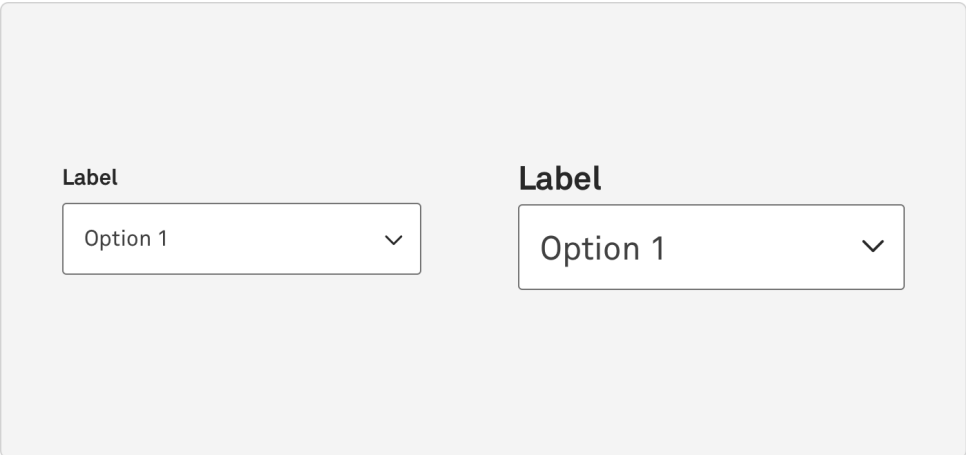
Some screen readers will also announce:

- The collapsed/expanded state of the select
- The number of items in the options list
- The position of an option within the list.

Tappable Area

Select has a minimum height of 52px that allows users to easily change their selection.

Capabilities



Robust Layout.

Components are scaled automatically based on the font size and zoom level in user's browser settings.

Related Patterns

- Radio Group
- Checkbox Group
- Text Field

No labels